

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 446

By Watson

A RESOLUTION to honor the Chattanooga Mocs men's basketball team on winning the 2025 National Invitation Tournament.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that this General Assembly should salute those student athletes who, through their extraordinary efforts, have distinguished themselves as true champions of whom we can all be proud; and

WHEREAS, one such exemplary group of young men is the Mocs basketball team of the University of Tennessee at Chattanooga (UTC or Chattanooga), whose members have proven themselves to be the fiercest of competitors and truly worthy of admiration by winning the 2025 National Invitation Tournament (NIT), a victory that made history; and

WHEREAS, the 2025 NIT crown is UTC's first NCAA-sanctioned tournament title in its Division I history, as well as the first such title won by any Southern Conference (SoCon) program in the conference's 105-year history; and

WHEREAS, Chattanooga also matched a school record for total wins, finishing with a 29-9 overall record; the Mocs closed out the 2024-2025 season on a tremendous hot streak, winning seventeen of their final eighteen games; and

WHEREAS, after winning the SoCon regular season championship with a 15-3 record, Chattanooga fell in the semifinals of the SoCon tournament for their final loss of the season; and

WHEREAS, determined to get revenge for that loss, UTC entered the NIT with a determined outlook and a chip on their shoulders and proceeded to win five straight games; and

WHEREAS, the Mocs defeated Middle Tennessee State 109-103 in a triple overtime thriller and then knocked off Dayton 87-72 in the second round; and

WHEREAS, Chattanooga bested Bradley 67-65 in the quarterfinal round and defeated Loyola-Chicago 80-73 in their semifinal match-up to advance to the title game; and

WHEREAS, the championship tilt between Chattanooga and UC Irvine was one of the best postseason basketball games of the year, featuring fourteen lead changes and nine ties, and neither team led by more than eight points during the contest; and

WHEREAS, Chattanooga scored with eleven seconds remaining in overtime to take a one-point lead; the Mocs then survived a last-second attempt to claim the 2025 NIT title with a thrilling 85-84 victory at the historic Hinkle Fieldhouse; and

WHEREAS, the Mocs were led to the promised land by NIT Most Valuable Player Trey Bonham, who scored 19 points and pulled 10 rebounds; Collin Mulholland, who also put up 19 points; All-Tournament selection Honor Huff, who scored 14 points; Garrison Keeslar, who made the game-winning bucket and finished with 14 points, 10 rebounds, and five assists; and Bash Wieland, who performed yeoman's duty in posting nine points, seven rebounds, and four assists; and

WHEREAS, the UTC squad also included contributing players, Jack Kostel, Sean Cusano, Latif Diouf, Makai Richards, Parker Robison, Noah Melson, Ryan Lopez, Frank Champion, Houston Holland, Liam Vitters, and Isaiah Otyaluk; and

WHEREAS, Chattanooga's NIT title would not have been possible without the expert guidance of Head Coach Dan Earl; his assistant coaches, Ander Galfsky, Scott Greenman, and Ricardo Rush, Jr.; and Director of Basketball Operations Alan Treakle; and

WHEREAS, the 2025 NIT title stands alongside the Mocs' league-best thirteen regular-season SoCon titles and league-best twelve SoCon Tournament titles, UTC's 1997 run to the Sweet Sixteen in the NCAA Tournament, and Chattanooga's 1977 NCAA Division II National Title as one of the program's crowning achievements; and

WHEREAS, we find it appropriate to acknowledge and applaud the UTC Mocs for their historic season on the hardwood; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and congratulate the members and coaches of the Chattanooga Mocs men's basketball team on winning the 2025 National Invitation Tournament, the historic first Division I tournament title in UTC and Southern Conference history, and extend to them our best wishes for every continued success in all their future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.